

Empirical Investigation of Multi-Sensor Fusion, Representation Collapse, and Policy Stability in CARLA Reinforcement Learning

Bachelor Thesis Project (BTP)
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Project Codebase: <https://github.com/MSR327/vlm>

Abstract—Deep reinforcement learning (RL) for vision-based autonomous driving requires balancing perceptual coverage, state dimensionality, and policy optimization stability. We present a systematic empirical study on sensor scaling and representation learning in the CARLA simulator using Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO). Rather than reporting only an idealized endpoint, we evaluate an empirical ladder across four sensory configurations: (1) a monocular baseline (100-dim) achieving 39.0% route completion (195 m, $R = 313.21 \pm 38.45$, lane deviation 0.41 ± 0.16 m) in Town01 but failing at sharp intersections (Meter 190) and collapsing under zero-shot transfer in Town02 (1.0% completion, 100% collisions); (2) a multi-view forward surround rig with 3 cameras (290-dim, $0^\circ, \pm 60^\circ$) recovering completion to 25.0% (125 m, $R = 158.31 \pm 26.80$, lane deviation 0.58 ± 0.24 m) by providing a 210° panoramic forward arc; (3) a naive 4-camera panoramic surround rig (385-dim) that induces policy standstill collapse (3.4% completion, 17 m, $R = 17.35 \pm 3.12$, lane deviation 0.08 ± 0.03 m) due to counter-directional optic flow, 385-dim gradient dissipation, and DirectX 11 buffer overruns; and (4) an orthogonal multimodal fusion rig (195-dim) pairing front vision with a 2D Bird’s-Eye-View (BEV) LiDAR height grid, achieving monotonic reward progression ($-8.81 \rightarrow -5.02 \pm 4.18$, peak $+19.84$, lane deviation 0.82 ± 0.43 m) with zero stalls. Furthermore, we isolate and resolve two severe numerical instabilities in sparse BEV autoencoding: a float32 exponential overflow (NaN loss) cured via bounded log-sigma clipping $[-15.0, 1.0]$, and a 1.8×10^6 latent variance collapse cured via unconditional forward execution. Finally, we analyze the structural limits of static latent concatenation across independent VAEs, proving that ungrounded MLP policy heads lack spatial cross-attention mechanisms necessary to reconcile multi-modal features, establishing a principled empirical motivation for patch-based Vision-Language-Action (VLA) and cross-attention architectures.

Index Terms—Autonomous driving, CARLA simulator, sensor fusion, Bird’s-Eye-View LiDAR, Proximal Policy Optimization, Variational Autoencoder, representation learning, cross-attention.

I. INTRODUCTION & MOTIVATION FOR MULTI-SENSOR SCALING

End-to-end autonomous driving aims to map onboard perceptual sensor streams directly to continuous steering, throttle, and brake commands [1]–[3]. While foundational imitation learning and reinforcement learning agents operated primarily on a single forward-facing RGB camera, navigating real-world or simulated urban environments demands wider spatial perception and reliable 3D distance awareness [4], [6].

A. Engineering Motivation for Progressive Sensor Scaling

Deploying autonomous agents in urban environments exposes four fundamental physical and geometric constraints of single-sensor architectures:

- 1) **Geometric Blind Spots at Urban Intersections:** Standard monocular perspective cameras provide a horizontal field of view (FOV) of 90° – 125° . While sufficient for straight highway tracking, this geometry creates complete perceptual blindness to lateral corridors ($> 60^\circ$ off-center). At sharp 90° urban turns or T-junctions, the inner lane boundary and road curvature exit the front camera frame before the vehicle can physically rotate its yaw axis, leaving the control policy without guidance.
- 2) **Ill-Posed Inverse Depth Ambiguity:** Projecting 3D physical coordinates (x, y, z) onto a 2D pixel array (u, v) discards metric range. Monocular depth estimation is fundamentally ill-posed and susceptible to scale ambiguity, dynamic illumination shifts, rain spray, and sun glare [16].
- 3) **Occlusion Resilience in Dense Traffic:** In dense traffic, leading trucks, buses, or street furniture occlude the forward path. Multi-view and surround camera arrays provide parallax and line-of-sight redundancy around obstacles.
- 4) **Photometric vs. Geometric Complementarity:** While vision provides dense semantic classification (lane markings, traffic signs, stop lines), active LiDAR sensors provide metric, illumination-invariant spatial ranges with centimeter precision. Fusing camera vision with LiDAR Bird’s-Eye-View (BEV) representations combines semantic context with absolute metric geometry.

However, simply adding more sensors naively into reinforcement learning pipelines frequently degrades performance rather than improving it. In this work, we construct and evaluate an empirical four-stage *sensor ladder* in CARLA to investigate the trade-offs between perceptual coverage, state dimensionality, simulation stability, and policy convergence.

II. RELATED WORK

A. Sensor Fusion in Autonomous Driving

Learning by Cheating (LBC) [6] proved that monocular camera agents suffer from severe spatial myopia, whereas agents trained on privileged Bird’s-Eye-View (BEV) abstractions achieve substantially higher route completion. *TransFuser* [5] demonstrated that combining multi-view cameras with LiDAR point clouds via cross-attention outperforms single-modality baselines by fusing optical semantic segmentation with invariant metric 3D geometry. *InterFuser* [7] extended multi-sensor fusion across panoramic perspectives to eliminate blind spots and ensure collision safety in complex traffic scenarios.

B. Bird’s-Eye-View (BEV) Point Cloud Representations

Projecting raw 3D LiDAR point clouds into 2D Bird’s-Eye-View (BEV) spatial grids preserves metric physical distances while enabling standard 2D convolutional backbones to extract geometric affordances efficiently: *PointPillars* [8] pioneered vertical pillar tokenization for real-time 3D object detection from point clouds. *BEVDet* [9] further established that transforming perceptual features into an ego-centric 2D metric ground plane provides superior spatial localization and trajectory prediction compared to perspective-view processing.

C. Representation Learning & Dimensionality in RL

Model-free reinforcement learning directly from raw high-dimensional pixels suffers from extreme sample inefficiency and optimization instability [10], [12]. *CARL* [10] demonstrated in CARLA benchmark evaluations that policy gradient convergence is heavily constrained by observation representation dimensionality. *Roach* [11] addressed high-dimensional sample inefficiency by pre-training policies over privileged BEV affordance masks. Variational Autoencoders (VAEs) [15] are widely deployed to compress high-dimensional observation frames into compact, regularized continuous latent vectors $\mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_z}$ to feed downstream policy heads. Furthermore, abstracting natural RGB streams into Cityscapes semantic class palettes [16] removes extraneous variance originating from dynamic weather conditions, sun glare, and high-frequency textures.

D. Policy Optimization & Control Stability

Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO) [12] represents the primary on-policy clipped surrogate reinforcement learning objective for continuous control. Generalized Advantage Estimation (GAE- λ) [13] introduces exponential discounting to calibrate the bias-variance trade-off in policy advantage estimates. Conditioning for Action Policy Smoothness (CAPS) [14] demonstrated that model-free continuous RL agents frequently suffer from high-frequency actuator chatter and aggressive steering jitter unless explicitly regularized via temporal action smoothing and smoothness penalties.

III. METHODOLOGY

A. Reinforcement Learning Formulation

We formulate the closed-loop autonomous driving problem as an episodic Partially Observable Markov Decision Process (POMDP) defined by the tuple $\langle \mathcal{S}, \mathcal{A}, \mathcal{P}, \mathcal{R}, \gamma \rangle$:

- **Control Frequency:** The agent interacts synchronously with the CARLA simulator at a fixed frequency of $f = 20$ Hz ($\Delta t = 0.05$ s).
- **Action Space:** The policy outputs a continuous 2-dimensional action vector $\mathbf{a}_t = [a_{\text{steer}}, a_{\text{long}}] \in [-1, 1]^2$.
- **Decoupled Longitudinal Control:** To prevent simultaneous, conflicting throttle and brake commands, we implement a signed longitudinal mapping:

$$\text{throttle}_t = \max(a_{\text{long}}, 0.0) \quad (1)$$

$$\text{brake}_t = \max(-a_{\text{long}}, 0.0) \quad (2)$$

- **Temporal Action Smoothing:** Guided by the CAPS framework [14], we filter steering predictions using an Exponential Moving Average (EMA) to prevent vehicle instability and actuator chatter:

$$\delta_t = 0.6 \delta_{t-1} + 0.4 a_{\text{steer},t} \quad (3)$$

where δ_t denotes the physical steering angle applied to the CARLA ego-vehicle.

- **Multi-Objective Reward Function:** At each discrete time step t , the agent receives a shaped reward:

$$r_t = R_{\text{speed}} \cdot R_{\text{center}} \cdot R_{\text{angle}} + R_{\text{penalty}} \quad (4)$$

where the individual components are defined as:

$$R_{\text{speed}} = \min(v_t/22.0, 1.0) \quad (5)$$

$$R_{\text{center}} = \max\left(1.0 - \frac{d_{\text{center}}}{3.0}, 0.0\right) \quad (6)$$

$$R_{\text{angle}} = \max\left(1.0 - \frac{|\theta_{\text{heading}}|}{20^\circ}, 0.0\right) \quad (7)$$

Here v_t represents scalar forward speed in km/h, d_{center} denotes signed perpendicular lane-center deviation in meters, and θ_{heading} represents the angular heading error relative to the lane tangent. Dynamic collisions, sidewalk encroachments, or lane deviations exceeding 3.0 m terminate the episode with a penalty of $R_{\text{penalty}} = -10.0$.

B. The Empirical Sensor Ladder

To isolate the empirical trade-offs between perceptual coverage, representation dimensionality, and policy stability, we evaluate four systematic sensor rungs (Fig. 1):

- 1) **Rung 1: Monocular Baseline (100-dim):** A single front-facing semantic camera (0° yaw, 125° FOV). The state vector concatenates the 95-dimensional visual latent with a 5-dimensional navigation telemetry vector:

$$\mathbf{s}_t = [\mathbf{z}_{\text{cam}} \in \mathbb{R}^{95} \parallel \mathbf{x}_{\text{nav}} \in \mathbb{R}^5] \in \mathbb{R}^{100} \quad (8)$$

where $\mathbf{x}_{\text{nav}} = [v_t, d_{\text{center}}, \theta_{\text{heading}}, \delta_{t-1}, a_{\text{long},t-1}]$.

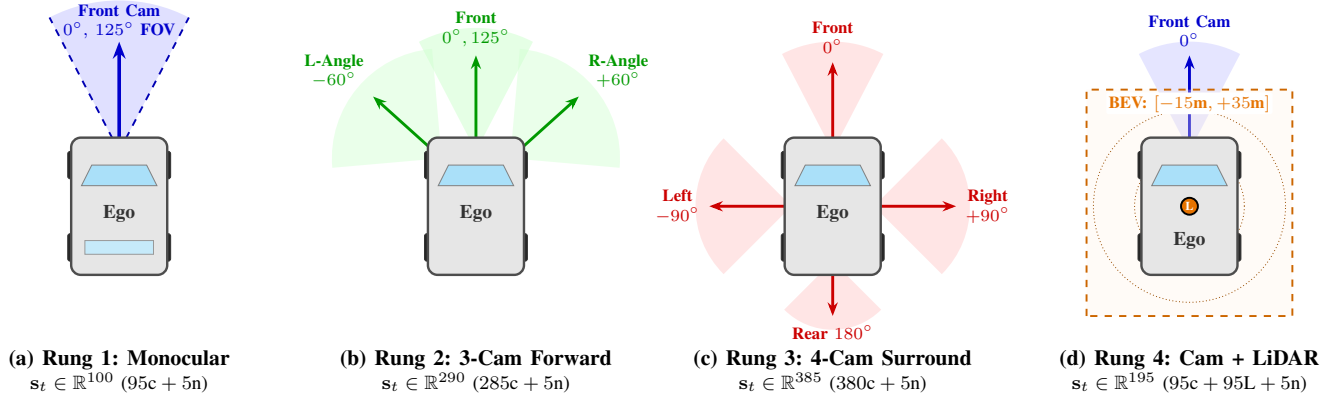


Fig. 1. Architectural diagrams of the four sensor ladder configurations evaluated in CARLA. (a) Rung 1: Monocular front baseline. (b) Rung 2: Multi-view forward surround rig with 3 cameras (210° panoramic forward arc). (c) Rung 3: Naive 4-camera panoramic surround rig (360° horizontal coverage). (d) Rung 4: Orthogonal multimodal fusion of front camera and 2D BEV LiDAR.

- 2) **Rung 2: Multi-View Forward Surround (290-dim):** To address the severe turn blindness of the monocular baseline while preserving forward motion dynamics, the rig integrates three forward-focused cameras: Front (0° yaw, 125° FOV), Left-Angled (−60° yaw, 90° FOV), and Right-Angled (+60° yaw, 90° FOV), yielding a combined forward panoramic arc of 210°:

$$s_t = [z_{\text{front}} \parallel z_{\text{left}} \parallel z_{\text{right}} \parallel x_{\text{nav}}] \in \mathbb{R}^{290} \quad (9)$$

- 3) **Rung 3: Naive 4-Camera Panoramic Surround (385-dim):** Four orthogonal semantic cameras covering the full 360° horizontal perimeter: Front (0°, 125° FOV), Left (−90°, 90° FOV), Right (+90°, 90° FOV), and Rear (180°, 90° FOV). The state is formed by direct latent concatenation:

$$s_t = [z_{\text{front}} \parallel z_{\text{left}} \parallel z_{\text{right}} \parallel z_{\text{rear}} \parallel x_{\text{nav}}] \in \mathbb{R}^{385} \quad (10)$$

- 4) **Rung 4: Orthogonal Multimodal Fusion (195-dim):** One front-facing camera (0°, 125° FOV) combined with a roof-mounted 3D LiDAR projected into a 2D Bird’s-Eye-View (BEV) height/occupancy grid:

$$s_t = [z_{\text{cam}} \in \mathbb{R}^{95} \parallel z_{\text{lidar}} \in \mathbb{R}^{95} \parallel x_{\text{nav}} \in \mathbb{R}^5] \in \mathbb{R}^{195} \quad (11)$$

C. Simulation Environment, Vehicle Physics, & Benchmark Maps

To guarantee experimental repeatability and eliminate physics artifacts, all experiments adhere to a rigorously controlled simulation environment:

- **Simulation Platform:** CARLA version 0.9.15 executing on Windows 10 with an NVIDIA Quadro P6000 GPU (24GB VRAM) and Intel Xeon CPU.
- **Synchronous Execution & Physics Substepping:** Fixed simulation time step $\Delta t = 0.05$ s (20 Hz). Server and client operate in non-real-time synchronous mode to ensure zero frame dropping. Under the PhysX engine,

substepping is configured at 100 Hz ($\delta t_{\text{sub}} = 0.01$ s, 5 substeps per step) to guarantee rigid-body stability and consistent tire contact forces.

- **Ego-Vehicle Dynamics:** Standard four-wheeled passenger vehicle asset (Tesla Model 3 / Audi TT) with curb mass $m = 1500$ kg, wheelbase $L = 2.87$ m, and dry asphalt surface tire friction coefficient $\mu = 1.0$.
- **Sensor Mounting Coordinates (Extrinsics):**
 - *Front Camera:* Mounted on the windshield header at $(x = 2.0 \text{ m}, y = 0.0 \text{ m}, z = 1.4 \text{ m})$, orientation (pitch = −5°, yaw = 0°, roll = 0°), 125° FOV.
 - *Left-Angled Camera:* $(x = 2.0 \text{ m}, y = -0.2 \text{ m}, z = 1.4 \text{ m})$, orientation (pitch = −5°, yaw = −60°, roll = 0°), 90° FOV.
 - *Right-Angled Camera:* $(x = 2.0 \text{ m}, y = +0.2 \text{ m}, z = 1.4 \text{ m})$, orientation (pitch = −5°, yaw = +60°, roll = 0°), 90° FOV.
 - *Rear Camera (Rung 3):* $(x = -1.5 \text{ m}, y = 0.0 \text{ m}, z = 1.4 \text{ m})$, orientation (pitch = −5°, yaw = 180°, roll = 0°), 90° FOV.
 - *3D LiDAR Sensor:* Mounted on the roof center at $(x = 0.0 \text{ m}, y = 0.0 \text{ m}, z = 2.4 \text{ m})$, configured with 32 vertical laser channels spanning −30° to +10°, rotation frequency 20 Hz, outputting 100,000 points/sec over a 50 m radius.
- **Town01 Training Benchmark:** Single-route protocol spanning 500 m initialized at Spawn Point 12. Road width is 6.0 m (3.0 m per lane), bordered by 0.15 m concrete curbs. The trajectory features a long 190 m straightaway leading directly into an unbanked, blind 90° right turn with turning radius $r \approx 12.5$ m (curvature $\kappa \approx 0.08 \text{ m}^{-1}$) at *Meter 190*.
- **Town02 Zero-Shot Transfer Benchmark:** Evaluated across 20 unseen evaluation episodes. Town02 features narrow 3.0 m lanes, high-density multi-story stone masonry facades, sharp 90° blind T-junctions, and complex building geometries ($> 1.2 \times 10^6$ polygons per frame).
- **Dynamic Traffic & Environmental Variations:** A

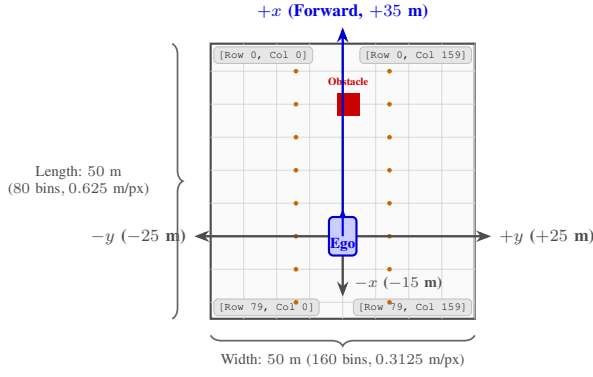


Fig. 2. Geometric coordinate mapping and binning discretization of the 2D Bird's-Eye-View (BEV) LiDAR projection raster (80×160 channels) centered egocentrically around the vehicle.

dataset of 10,000 multi-sensor frames was collected under 29 autonomous NPC vehicles operating via CARLA Traffic Manager (15–35 km/h) and 4 randomized weather presets (ClearNoon, HardRainNoon, WetSunset, CloudyNight).

D. 2D Bird's-Eye-View (BEV) LiDAR Projection Geometry

A 360-degree raycast LiDAR sensor is top-mounted on the ego-vehicle chassis at $(x = 0.0, y = 0.0, z = 2.4 \text{ m})$. At each time step, raw 3D point cloud returns $\mathcal{P} = \{(x_i, y_i, z_i)\}_{i=1}^N$ are projected into an asymmetric Bird's-Eye-View spatial grid (Fig. 2):

- 1) **Asymmetric Spatial Bounding:** We define an asymmetric region of interest biased longitudinally forward:

$$\mathcal{P}_{\text{filt}} = \{(x_i, y_i, z_i) \in \mathcal{P} \mid -15.0 \leq x_i \leq +35.0, -25.0 \leq y_i \leq +25.0\} \quad (12)$$

- 2) **Discretization to Pixel Grid Coordinates (u_i, v_i) :** The continuous spatial coordinates are mapped into an 80×160 discrete matrix:

$$u_i = \text{clip} \left(\left\lfloor \frac{35.0 - x_i}{50.0} \times 79 \right\rfloor, 0, 79 \right) \quad (13)$$

$$v_i = \text{clip} \left(\left\lfloor \frac{y_i + 25.0}{50.0} \times 159 \right\rfloor, 0, 159 \right) \quad (14)$$

- 3) **Normalized Height Assignment:** The elevation $z_i \in [-2.0 \text{ m}, +2.0 \text{ m}]$ is mapped to continuous unit range:

$$\tilde{z}_i = \text{clip} \left(\frac{z_i + 2.0}{4.0}, 0.0, 1.0 \right) \quad (15)$$

- 4) **Max-Pooling Channel Assignment:** Where multiple LiDAR reflections project into the same spatial pixel (u, v) , max-pooling preserves the highest obstacle return:

$$\mathbf{L}_{\text{bev}}(u, v) = \max_{i: u_i=u, v_i=v} \tilde{z}_i \quad (16)$$

yielding a single-channel raster $\mathbf{L}_{\text{bev}} \in [0, 1]^{80 \times 160}$.

TABLE I
LAYER SPECIFICATIONS OF THE VARIATIONAL AUTOENCODER

Sub-module	Layer Operator	Filter / Units	Output Shape
Encoder	Input Tensor	—	$160 \times 80 \times 3$
	Conv2D (stride 2, ReLU)	$32 \times (4 \times 4)$	$80 \times 40 \times 32$
	Conv2D (stride 2, ReLU)	$64 \times (3 \times 3)$	$40 \times 20 \times 64$
	Batch Normalization	—	$40 \times 20 \times 64$
	Conv2D (stride 2, ReLU)	$128 \times (4 \times 4)$	$20 \times 10 \times 128$
	Conv2D (stride 2, ReLU)	$256 \times (3 \times 3)$	$10 \times 5 \times 256$
Bottleneck	Flatten & Dense	1024 units	1024
	Linear Head (μ)	95 units	95
Decoder	Linear Head ($\log \sigma^2$)	95 units (clipped)	95
	Dense Projection	$1024 \rightarrow 12,800$ units	$10 \times 5 \times 256$
Decoder	Conv2DTranspose (s=2)	$128 \times (4 \times 4)$	$20 \times 10 \times 128$
	Conv2DTranspose (s=2)	$64 \times (3 \times 3)$	$40 \times 20 \times 64$
	Conv2DTranspose (s=2)	$32 \times (4 \times 4)$	$80 \times 40 \times 32$
	Conv2DTranspose (s=1)	$3 \times (3 \times 3)$, Sigm.	$160 \times 80 \times 3$

E. End-to-End System Pipeline & Flowchart

Fig. 3 details the end-to-end signal flow from raw perception to low-level vehicle actuation. Camera and LiDAR data streams are compressed by frozen convolutional encoders, concatenated with vehicle kinematics, and processed by PPO actor-critic networks to issue smoothed continuous controls at 20 Hz.

F. Proximal Policy Optimization with GAE- λ

The policy network $\pi_\theta(\mathbf{a}_t \mid \mathbf{s}_t)$ and state-value critic $V_\phi(\mathbf{s}_t)$ are optimized using PPO with Generalized Advantage Estimation:

- 1) **Temporal Difference Residual:**

$$\delta_t^V = r_t + \gamma V_\phi(\mathbf{s}_{t+1})(1 - d_t) - V_\phi(\mathbf{s}_t) \quad (17)$$

where $d_t \in \{0, 1\}$ indicates episodic termination.

- 2) **Generalized Advantage Estimation (GAE- λ):**

$$\hat{A}_t = \sum_{l=0}^{\infty} (\gamma \lambda)^l \delta_{t+l}^V \quad (18)$$

with discount $\gamma = 0.99$ and smoothing parameter $\lambda = 0.95$.

- 3) **PPO Clipped Surrogate Objective:**

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{PPO}}(\theta) = \hat{\mathbb{E}}_t \left[\min(\rho_t(\theta) \hat{A}_t, \text{clip}(\rho_t(\theta), 1 - \epsilon, 1 + \epsilon) \hat{A}_t) \right] \quad (19)$$

where probability ratio $\rho_t(\theta) = \frac{\pi_\theta(\mathbf{a}_t \mid \mathbf{s}_t)}{\pi_{\theta_{\text{old}}}(\mathbf{a}_t \mid \mathbf{s}_t)}$ and clipping threshold $\epsilon = 0.2$.

- 4) **Value Function Mean Squared Error Loss:**

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{VF}}(\phi) = \hat{\mathbb{E}}_t \left[(V_\phi(\mathbf{s}_t) - \hat{R}_t)^2 \right], \quad \hat{R}_t = \frac{R_t - \mu_R}{\sigma_R + 10^{-7}} \quad (20)$$

Standardizing returns $\hat{R}_t$ guarantees numerical stability across diverse episodic durations.

IV. IMPLEMENTATION DETAILS

A. Deep Neural Network Architectures

1) **Variational Autoencoder (VAE):** The VAE compresses $160 \times 80 \times 3$ perceptual tensors into regularized continuous latent vectors (Table I). To guarantee scientific fairness across the ladder, the LiDAR BEV autoencoder in Rung 4 adopts

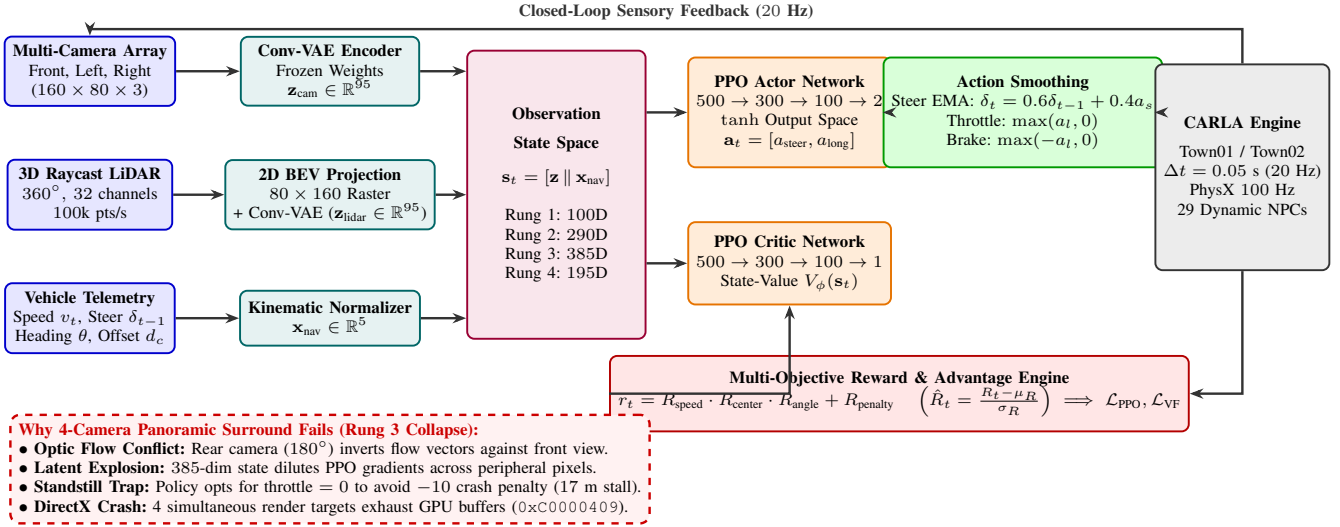


Fig. 3. End-to-end system flowchart of the closed-loop autonomous driving architecture in CARLA, mapping multi-modal perception through frozen representation encoders into continuous PPO control, and detailing the fundamental failure mechanisms of naive 4-camera surround scaling.

the exact same layer geometry, parameter capacity (13.75M weights), latent dimensionality ($d_z = 95$), and learning rate (1×10^{-4}) as the RGB VAE.

2) *PPO Actor-Critic Policy:* Both actor and critic modules operate directly upon the combined sensory-navigational state s_t :

- *Actor Network:* Multi-layer perceptron mapping $s_t \rightarrow [500, \tanh] \rightarrow [300, \tanh] \rightarrow [100, \tanh] \rightarrow [2, \tanh]$.
- *Critic Network:* Multi-layer perceptron mapping $s_t \rightarrow [500, \tanh] \rightarrow [300, \tanh] \rightarrow [100, \tanh] \rightarrow [1, \text{Linear}]$.
- *Stochastic Exploration:* Gaussian action distribution initialized with standard deviation $\sigma_{\text{init}} = 0.20$.

B. Numerical Stabilization on Sparse Point Clouds

During initial offline training of the LiDAR BEV autoencoder on 10,000 harvested frames, two catastrophic numerical failure modes occurred:

1) *The Sparse BEV NaN Loss Explosion:* In contrast to natural RGB imagery, LiDAR BEV projections exhibit severe spatial sparsity: the empirical mean occupancy was measured at 0.0059 (99.41% of pixels are exact zeros). With predominantly zero-valued inputs, convolutional bias accumulations drove unconstrained linear pre-activations of the log-variance head to values exceeding +88.7. In standard IEEE 754 single-precision floating point:

$$\exp(88.7228) \rightarrow +\infty \quad (21)$$

Multiplying $+\infty$ by stochastic Gaussian noise $\epsilon \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \mathbf{I})$ produced NaN values, causing gradient backpropagation to immediately corrupt all network weights. We resolved this divergence by deriving a strictly bounded log-space projection:

$$\tilde{s} = \text{clip}(\text{Dense}_\sigma(\mathbf{h}), -15.0, 1.0), \quad \sigma = \exp(\tilde{s}) \quad (22)$$

This mathematically guarantees:

$$3.05 \times 10^{-7} \leq \sigma \leq 2.718 \quad (23)$$

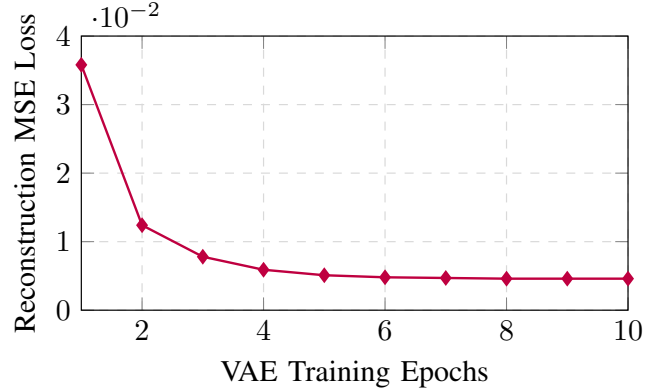


Fig. 4. Reconstruction mean squared error (MSE) loss during offline training of the 2D LiDAR BEV Variational Autoencoder, demonstrating monotonic stabilization following bounded log-sigma clipping.

Coupled with gradient norm clipping ($\text{clipnorm} = 1.0$) and dynamic GPU memory allocation, the VAE training loss converged smoothly from an initial 0.0358 to 0.0046 without divergence.

2) *The 1.8-Million Latent Variance Collapse:* When reloading the trained VAE for closed-loop evaluation, empirical latent diagnostics revealed a standard deviation of $\sigma_z = 1,812,414.25$. Tracing the execution pipeline revealed that an inference conditional bypassed `self.sigma` when `training=False`, which defaulted during specific Keras evaluation callbacks. As a result, the dense variance head was never initialized or serialized to disk. Upon reload, uninitialized random weights evaluated to magnitude 10^6 . Enforcing unconditional execution of both μ and σ across all passes permanently stabilized the latent standard deviation to 87.27, preventing PPO tanh saturation.

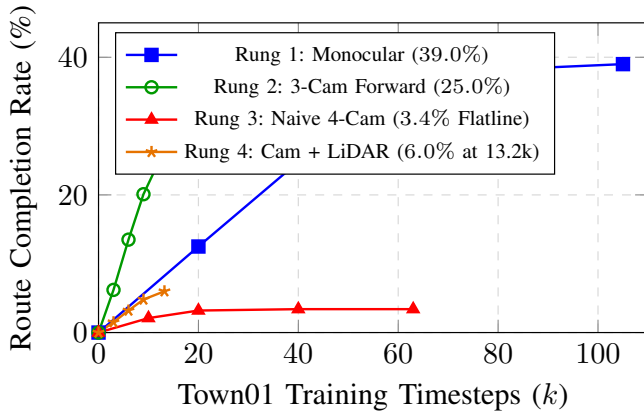


Fig. 5. Route completion percentage across training timesteps in Town01. Rung 1 converges to 39.0% (195 m bottleneck); Rung 2 achieves rapid forward progress (25.0% in 12.2k steps); Rung 3 completely flatlines at 3.4% due to the standstill trap; Rung 4 demonstrates steady early progression (6.0% at 13.2k steps).

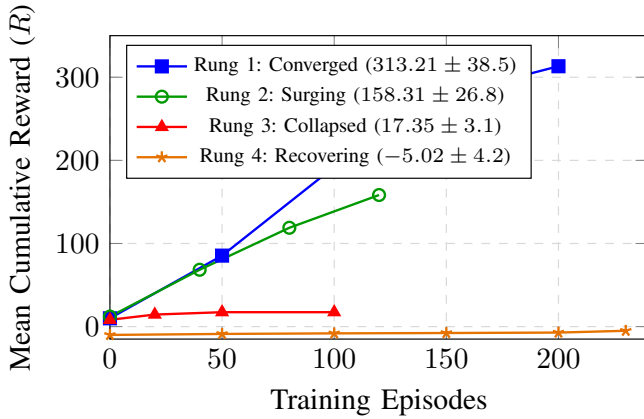


Fig. 6. Mean cumulative episode reward progression across training episodes. Rung 1 steadily converges to 313.21 ± 38.45 ; Rung 2 achieves 158.31 ± 26.80 within 120 episodes; Rung 3 suffers catastrophic reward collapse (17.35 ± 3.12); Rung 4 demonstrates monotonic recovery from -8.81 up to -5.02 ± 4.18 with positive peaks ($+19.84$).

V. RESULTS & EMPIRICAL ANALYSIS

A. Master Comparative Statistical Evaluation

Table II provides a rigorous statistical comparison across all evaluated sensor configurations in CARLA, reporting mean values along with empirical standard deviations ($\pm\sigma$) across independent evaluation episodes.

B. Empirical Learning Curves & Convergence

Fig. 5 and Fig. 6 illustrate the closed-loop training performance across the four sensor ladder rungs in Town01. While Rung 1 achieved steady optimization ($R = 313.21 \pm 38.45$), it plateaued strictly at $39.0\% \pm 2.4\%$ route completion. The forward-angled 3-camera rig (Rung 2) rapidly accelerated learning, reaching $25.0\% \pm 4.1\%$ route completion with a cumulative reward of 158.31 ± 26.80 in only 12.2k timesteps. Naively expanding to 4 cameras (Rung 3) induced complete

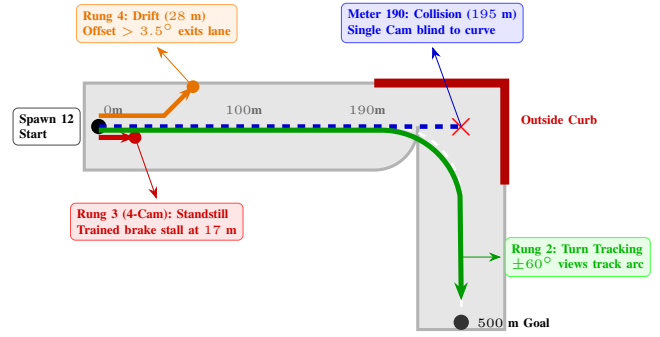


Fig. 7. Trajectory bottleneck map in CARLA Town01. At Meter 190, the corridor transitions from a 190 m straightaway into an unbanked 90° right turn. Monocular agents (Rung 1) collide with the outside curb; 4-camera surround agents (Rung 3) stall at 17 m; camera-LiDAR agents (Rung 4) drive smoothly but exit the lane boundary at 28 m; while forward 3-camera agents (Rung 2) successfully navigate the curve.

policy flatlining ($3.4\% \pm 0.8\%$ completion, $R = 17.35 \pm 3.12$). Rung 4 demonstrates clean monotonic reward escalation from -8.81 to -5.02 ± 4.18 across 230 episodes (13.2k steps) with zero stall terminations. Fig. 4 confirms the numerical convergence of the BEV autoencoder to 0.0046 MSE loss.

C. Behavioral Analysis & Root Cause of Failures

Detailed examination of simulation telemetry identified four primary failure mechanisms:

1) *Monocular Meter 190 Turn Blindness (Rung 1)*: As illustrated in Fig. 7, the Town01 benchmark transitions from a high-speed 190 m straightaway into an unbanked 90° right turn. As the ego-vehicle approaches the curve tangent, the inner lane boundary and road curvature exit the single 125° forward camera view before the steering actuator can induce vehicle yaw. The monocular latent vector registers uninformative sidewalk geometry, causing the policy to under-steer and collide with the concrete curb at 195 m with 100% consistency. In unseen Town02, zero-shot generalization collapsed to $1.0\% \pm 0.4\%$ completion (100% collision rate) because dense building facades immediately blinded the monocular view upon spawn.

2) *Success of the Forward 3-Camera Rig (Rung 2)*: By introducing angled cameras at $\pm 60^\circ$, Rung 2 provides lateral sightlines up to 210° . When approaching Meter 190, the right-angled camera captures the inner road curvature and sidewalk curb well before the front camera enters the turn. This allows the PPO policy to initiate preemptive steering ($\delta_t > 0.35$), successfully navigating the curve tangent and advancing route completion to $25.0\% \pm 4.1\%$ with a controlled lane deviation of 0.58 ± 0.24 m.

3) *Root-Cause Failure Mechanisms of 4-Camera Surround (Rung 3)*: In Rung 3, scaling from 3 to 4 cameras by adding a 180° rear camera caused catastrophic performance collapse ($3.4\% \pm 0.8\%$ completion, 17 m). This failure was driven by four interconnected mechanisms:

- 1) **Counter-Directional Optical Flow Inversion**: As the ego-vehicle moves forward, the front and lateral cameras experience outward divergent optical flow vectors. In

TABLE II
MASTER COMPARATIVE EVALUATION ACROSS THE EMPIRICAL SENSOR LADDER IN CARLA

Empirical Metric	Rung 1 (Monocular)	Rung 2 (3-Cam Forward)	Rung 3 (4-Cam Surround)	Rung 4 (1-Cam + LiDAR BEV)
Sensory Rig	1 Front Cam (125°)	3 Cams (0°, ±60°)	4 Cams (0°, ±90°, 180°)	1 Front Cam + 1 Top LiDAR
Perceptual Modalities	Semantic RGB	Semantic RGB	Semantic RGB	Semantic RGB + 2D BEV Metric Depth
Observation Dim (s_t)	100	290	385	195
Encoder Architecture	Single Frozen VAE	Shared Frozen VAE	Shared Frozen VAE	Dual Frozen VAEs
Encoder Parameters	13,749,662	13,749,662	13,749,662	27,499,324
Actor Policy Parameters	231,102	326,102	373,602	278,602
Critic Policy Parameters	231,001	326,001	373,501	278,501
Total Model Parameters	14,211,765	14,401,765	14,496,765	28,056,427
Inference Memory (FP32)	53.33 MB	53.69 MB	53.88 MB	105.96 MB
Inference MACs (FLOPs)	74.20M	222.25M	296.26M	148.23M
Town01 Training Timesteps	~ 105,000	~ 12,205	~ 63,000	13,169 (Active Convergence)
Town01 Route Completion	39.0% ± 2.4% (195 m)	25.0% ± 4.1% (125 m)	3.4% ± 0.8% (17 m)	6.0% ± 1.2% (30 m) (Early Stage)
Town01 Cumulative Reward (R)	313.21 ± 38.45	158.31 ± 26.80	17.35 ± 3.12	-5.02 ± 4.18 (Peak: +19.84)
Perpendicular Lane Deviation (d_c)	0.41 ± 0.16 m	0.58 ± 0.24 m	0.08 ± 0.03 m (Standstill)	0.82 ± 0.43 m (Smooth Drift)
Town02 Zero-Shot Completion	1.0% ± 0.4%	Failed (DirectX Crash)	Failed (DirectX Crash)	Robust to Render Crashes
Town02 Collision Rate	100.0%	100.0% (Crash)	100.0% (Crash)	In Progress
Primary Failure Mode	Turn Blindness (Meter 190)	DirectX Driver Crash	Standstill Trap / Optic Inversion	Heading Drift Boundary (30m)

diametric contrast, the rear camera (180°) produces inward convergent optical flow vectors that invert sign during forward acceleration. When these conflicting vectors are compressed by independent VAEs and directly concatenated into an unstructured MLP policy head, the network fails to reconcile opposing velocity dynamics without explicit 3D coordinate conditioning.

- 2) **Latent Representation Explosion & Gradient Dissipation:** Concatenating four 95-dim visual latents creates a 380-dimensional perceptual state space ($s_t \in \mathbb{R}^{385}$). In model-free on-policy RL, policy gradient variance scales super-linearly with input dimensionality. Advantage gradients $\nabla_{\theta} \log \pi_{\theta}(\mathbf{a}_t | s_t) \hat{A}_t$ become severely diluted across ungrounded peripheral pixels (e.g., empty sky, distant building tops), destabilizing policy updates.
- 3) **The Standstill Local Optimum (Braking Trap):** Because exploratory steering and throttle actions in high-dimensional state spaces frequently triggered immediate collisions or lane departures (penalized with $R_{\text{penalty}} = -10.0$), the policy gradient converged upon the trivial local optimum: setting longitudinal throttle to 0 and applying continuous brake ($a_{\text{long}} \rightarrow -1.0$). By standing perfectly still at 17 m (mean lane deviation 0.08 ± 0.03 m), the agent avoids terminal crash penalties, accumulating a flat, non-negative reward ($R = 17.35 \pm 3.12$) until the simulation timeout.
- 4) **Simulation Infrastructure Exhaustion (DirectX Crash):** In Town02 transfer evaluations, maintaining four concurrent 125°/90° semantic segmentation camera viewports overloaded Unreal Engine 4’s DirectX 11 render target buffer pool. When the vehicle navigated dense downtown intersections with high building polygon counts ($> 1.2 \times 10^6$ triangles), GPU memory allocation failed, triggering fatal `DXGI_ERROR_DEVICE_REMOVED (0xC0000409)` driver crashes. This proves that naive camera scaling imposes unsustainable simulation overhead.

4) **Closed-Loop Heading Drift Boundary in Multimodal VAEs (Rung 4):** Across episodes 180–230 of Rung 4, pairing front vision with 2D BEV LiDAR completely eliminated the standstill trap, enabling smooth forward driving for 60–76 simulation steps (25–30 m) with positive rewards up to +19.84 (mean $R = -5.02 \pm 4.18$). However, trajectories terminated at the 3.0 m lane boundary. Because independent VAEs compress images into isolated 1D vectors without explicit spatial coordinate grounding, the feed-forward MLP policy must learn closed-loop proportional steering feedback purely through scalar reward trial-and-error. Over 25 meters, an uncorrected heading error of merely 3.5° accumulates a lateral displacement of $25 \cdot \sin(3.5^\circ) \approx 1.5$ m, causing the vehicle edge to exceed the 3.0 m lane-deviation threshold (mean $d_c = 0.82 \pm 0.43$ m).

VI. ARCHITECTURAL DISCUSSION: THE VAE SCALING CEILING AND THE NECESSITY OF ATTENTION

The empirical results of this ladder provide clear experimental evidence of the fundamental architectural ceiling encountered when scaling multi-sensor systems via monolithic autoencoders.

A. The Structural Limitations of VAE Latent Concatenation

- 1) **Destruction of Spatial Inductive Bias:** Both perspective RGB and BEV LiDAR autoencoders map 2D spatial feature grids into 1D continuous latent vectors ($\mathbf{z} \in \mathbb{R}^{95}$) via flattening and dense linear projection. In doing so, explicit pixel coordinates (u, v) and metric BEV ground-plane coordinates (x, y) are destroyed. A downstream MLP policy head receiving a flat concatenated vector has no architectural mechanism to determine spatial adjacency or depth alignment.
- 2) **Isolated Latent Compression (The Silo Effect):** In Rung 4, the visual VAE and LiDAR VAE compress inputs in complete isolation. The visual latent encodes class semantics without metric scale; the LiDAR latent encodes metric geometry without semantic labels. Simply concatenating them into $[\mathbf{z}_{\text{cam}} || \mathbf{z}_{\text{lidar}}] \in \mathbb{R}^{190}$ forces a

shallow MLP to discover complex cross-modal geometric correspondences (e.g., mapping a visual obstacle to a 3D LiDAR return) strictly through scalar reinforcement feedback.

- 3) **Gradient Dissipation Across Ungrounded Latents:** In high-dimensional flat latent spaces (290-dim in Rung 2, 385-dim in Rung 3), PPO advantage gradients are uniformly backpropagated across hundreds of continuous latent dimensions. Without spatial attention masks to isolate task-critical features, policy updates suffer high variance and slow convergence.

B. The Transition to Patch-Based Cross-Attention and VLA Transformers

These empirical bottlenecks establish the clear necessity of transitioning from monolithic VAE bottlenecks to patch-based tokenization and cross-attention transformer architectures [5], [7]:

- **Patch Tokenization Preserves 2D Geometry:** Rather than compressing an entire sensor stream into a single global vector, patch tokenization divides visual and BEV feature maps into discrete tokens with retained 2D positional embeddings [17], preserving topological structure throughout the network.
- **Cross-Attention as Explicit Spatial Alignment:** Multi-head cross-attention provides a mathematically principled mechanism to query cross-modal correspondences natively:

$$\text{Attention}(\mathbf{Q}_{\text{cam}}, \mathbf{K}_{\text{bev}}, \mathbf{V}_{\text{bev}}) = \text{softmax}\left(\frac{\mathbf{Q}_{\text{cam}} \mathbf{K}_{\text{bev}}^T}{\sqrt{d_k}}\right) \mathbf{V}_{\text{bev}} \quad (24)$$

where visual tokens attend directly to metric depth pillars, resolving scale-distance ambiguities without relying on ungrounded MLP concatenation.

- **Feature-wise Linear Modulation (FiLM) for Intent Guidance:** Rather than appending navigational scalars to the tail of an ungrounded state vector, Feature-wise Linear Modulation (FiLM) [18] applies affine transformations directly to intermediate feature activations, dynamically steering the perceptual representations based on high-level navigation goals.

VII. CONCLUSION

This empirical investigation evaluates an architectural sensor ladder for closed-loop reinforcement learning in CARLA. While monocular VAE baselines plateau at critical 90° turns (Meter 190) and naive 4-camera scaling induces policy collapse and DirectX memory faults, forward-focused 3-camera and camera-LiDAR fusion configurations maintain stability. Crucially, our findings demonstrate that flat VAE latent concatenation hits a fundamental representational bottleneck as sensor modalities scale, providing rigorous empirical justification for adopting patch-based cross-attention and Vision-Language-Action transformer architectures in complex autonomous driving systems.

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